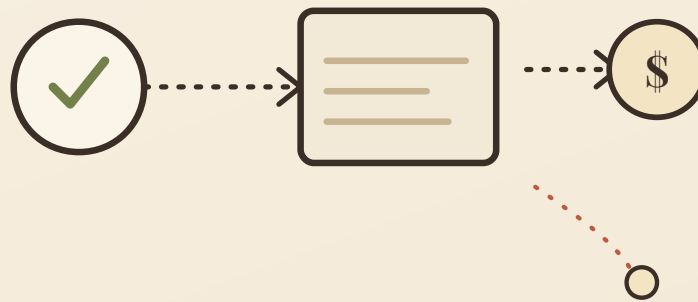


THE 0 TO 100 SERIES • PAID GUIDE

Affiliate Marketing

*The complete beginner's guide to building a real,
recurring commission business — no inventory, no
money down.*



0 TO 100 • AFFILIATE MARKETING EDITION

Ten Stages, Zero Fluff

PHASE 1 • FOUNDATION (0→50)

	Stage 1: Understand the model	0-10
	Stage 2: Pick a profitable niche	10-20
	Stage 3: Choose your programs and networks	20-30
	Stage 4: Build your platform	30-40
	Stage 5: Create your first content	40-50

PHASE 2 • SCALE (50→100)

	Stage 6: Traffic systems	50-60
	Stage 7: Email capture and sequences	60-70
	Stage 8: Conversion optimization	70-80
	Stage 9: Scaling winners	80-90
	Stage 10: Diversification and the long-term moat	90-100

Read This First

You're about to learn how affiliate marketing actually works — not the Lamborghini-thumbail version, the real one. The one where you build an asset over 6–18 months that pays you every month whether you worked that day or not.

Here's the honest deal: affiliate marketing is not fast money. Most people who try it earn \$0 because they quit in month two, right before anything compounds. But the model itself is one of the best businesses on earth for someone starting with no money — zero inventory, zero customer support, zero product creation.

Every stage ends with numbered action steps. Do them in order. A weak foundation is the #1 reason affiliate sites die.



Understand the model

so you never get scammed by a guru again

Affiliate marketing is simple: **a company pays you a commission for sending them a customer.** You get a unique tracking link; someone clicks it, buys, and you get a cut. The company handles product, shipping, refunds, and support. You handle one thing: putting the right offer in front of the right person at the right moment.

PART	WHAT IT IS	EXAMPLE
Merchant	The company with the product	A web hosting company
Network/Program	The tracking + payment layer	Impact, ShareASale, in-house
You (the affiliate)	The traffic and trust	Your blog, channel, newsletter
The audience	People with a problem	Someone Googling "best hosting"

Three commission flavors

1. **One-time percentage** (Amazon: 1–10%). Low per sale, easy conversions.
2. **One-time flat bounty** (\$65–150 for a hosting signup). High per sale, competitive.
3. **Recurring** (20–30% of a SaaS sub every month). 50 referred customers on a \$50/mo tool at 30% recurring = \$750/month, forever-ish.

✧ **The single most important mental shift:** you are not a seller. You are a *recommender*. Recommend garbage once for a fat commission and you've burned the only asset you have.

ACTION STEPS

1. Write down, in one sentence, how affiliate marketing works.
2. Find one affiliate link in the wild — Google "best standing desks," hover a product link, notice the tracking junk in the URL (?tag=, /go/).
3. Decide your weekly time budget honestly (5, 10, or 15+ hours) and write it down.



Pick a profitable niche

the decision that determines everything

A niche is topic + audience. "Fitness" is not a niche. "Home gym equipment for people in small apartments" is.

CATEGORY	WHY IT PAYS
Software/SaaS	Recurring commissions, 20-30%
Hosting/web services	\$50-150 bounties
Finance & B2B tools	High payouts (\$20-200/lead)
Hobbies with expensive gear	Passionate buyers
Career/skills	Course + tool commissions

The Niche Filter — your idea must pass all five

- At least 3 affiliate programs paying 20%+ or \$30+ per sale?
- Can you list 25 content ideas in 15 minutes?
- Are smaller/newer sites ranking and growing in it?
- Would you read about this topic anyway?
- Is it evergreen or growing, not a dying fad?

⚠ A good niche executed beats a perfect niche abandoned. Spend 3-5 days here, not 3 months.

ACTION STEPS

1. Brainstorm 10 topics you know, spend money on, or want to learn.
2. Run each through the 5-point filter; kill anything failing two or more.
3. For your top 2, Google "[niche] affiliate program" and log rates in a spreadsheet.
4. Pick one: "I help [specific person] with [specific problem] by recommending [category]."



Choose your programs and networks

where the money actually comes from

NETWORK	BEST FOR
Amazon Associates	Physical products — 1-10%, 24h cookie, converts insanely well
Impact	Big SaaS + brands, modern dashboard
ShareASale (Awin)	Mid-size brands, ecommerce, beginner-friendly
PartnerStack	B2B SaaS — recurring commissions live here
ClickBank / Digistore24	Digital info products — 50-75%, vet everything

Your portfolio: pick 3-5 programs total

1. One easy converter (usually Amazon Associates)
2. One or two recurring SaaS programs — your monthly baseline
3. One high-ticket program (\$50+ per sale)

✦ **The golden rule:** only promote things you'd recommend to a friend for free. Sign up for free trials, use the products, take your own screenshots.

ACTION STEPS

1. Sign up for Amazon Associates plus one network fitting your niche.
2. Google "[top 5 products] affiliate program" and note strong in-house/recurring options.
3. Build your 3-5 program shortlist with rate, cookie length, payout minimum.
4. Sign up for free trials of your top 2 SaaS picks and use them this week.



STAGE 4 • 30-40

Build your platform

free, in one weekend

Your platform is where content lives and links go. You need exactly **one** primary platform.

OPTION	BEST IF
Blog/website	Best long-term, beginner-friendly at \$0
YouTube	You'd rather talk than write
Social-first (+ Linktree)	Fastest first traffic, weakest durability — supplement only

Whatever you choose, set up these five things

1. A clean, specific name (niche + a word)
2. An honest about page: who you help and why
3. An affiliate disclosure — legally required by the FTC
4. Email capture from day one (free MailerLite, to 1,000 subs)
5. Google Search Console + GA4 if you built a site

⚠ Nobody cares about your logo, colors, and fonts. Content earns; design doesn't. Setup is one weekend max.



STAGE 5 • 40-50

Create your first content

the 20-piece foundation

Publish **20 pieces** aimed at people close to a buying decision: 6 roundups, 6 reviews, 4 comparisons, 4 how-tos.

The structure that converts

- Answer the question in the first 100 words (your #1 pick, with link)
- Comparison table near the top
- Honest detail per product: who it's for, who it's not, real screenshots
- Personal experience — your unfair advantage over AI-spam competitors

✦ **On AI tools:** use ChatGPT/Claude/Gemini for outlines and first drafts — then rewrite in your voice with your actual experience. Raw AI output puts you in a knife fight with a million identical sites.

\$0-\$50

MONTHS 1-3 TOTAL

2/week

CADENCE

20

PIECES TO PHASE 2

ACTION STEPS

1. Build a 20-idea list via Google autocomplete + your niche's subreddit.
2. Write your first “Best X for Y” roundup this week with links + disclosure.
3. Commit to 2 pieces/week, in your calendar like a job shift.

II

Scale

STAGES 6-10 · 50 → 100

Phase 1 built the machine: a niche, programs, a platform, and 20 published pieces. Now we feed it — traffic, email, conversion, and a moat.



STAGE 6 • 50-60

Traffic systems

from trickle to stream

Phase 1 traffic was passive. Phase 2 is systematic: deliberately build 2-3 repeatable channels.

1. **SEO (compounding base):** find pages ranking 5-20 in Search Console and upgrade them — position 8→3 can 5× traffic. Internal-link how-tos to money pages. Free backlinks via genuine Reddit/Quora answers and source-request services.
2. **One social channel:** Pinterest, YouTube Shorts/TikTok, or X/LinkedIn for B2B. Repurpose, don't create from scratch.
3. **Communities:** 10 helpful contributions for every 1 link.

✧ Traffic is lumpy — one page or video that hits can double your numbers overnight. That's why you published wide in Phase 1.



Email capture and sequences

the asset nobody can take from you

Your email list is the only audience you own. Conversion rates go from 1–3% to 5–15% because you're recommending to people who already trust you.

EMAIL	WHEN	JOB
1	Instantly	Deliver lead magnet, origin story
2	Day 2	Best free tip, zero links
3	Day 4	Your story + biggest beginner mistake
4	Day 6	Soft recommendation (affiliate link)
5	Day 9	Direct recommendation + case study

⚠ Amazon Associates prohibits affiliate links in emails — check each program's terms and link to your review page instead.

ACTION STEPS

1. Create one lead magnet this week (checklist or comparison sheet).
2. Add capture forms to your top 5 pages + a landing page.
3. Write and automate the 5-email welcome sequence.
4. Send one simple weekly email from now on, even to 9 subscribers.



STAGE 8 • 70-80

Conversion optimization

same traffic, more money

Doubling traffic is hard. Doubling conversion is often just fixing obvious problems.

The conversion audit — run on your top 10 pages

1. Is the recommendation above the fold?
2. Are there comparison tables?
3. Do links look like actions ("Try X free →")?
4. Is there proof — your screenshots, your results?
5. Does every page have ONE primary offer?
6. Trust markers: honest cons, "who shouldn't buy this"?

✦ **Also renegotiate:** once sales are consistent, email your affiliate managers and ask for a bumped rate or exclusive discount code. The worst they say is no.

30-100%

LIFT FROM CONVERSION WORK

\$500-\$2,000

MONTHS 8-12



Scaling winners

double down, ruthlessly

A few pieces of content, one or two programs, and one or two traffic sources produce most of your income. Scale means doing violently more of what works.

The cluster method

Take your best-earning page and surround it: build 4-6 supporting pieces that all internally link back to it. You dominate the whole topic and funnel every related search to the page that converts.

1. **Templates and checklists** for every repeated task — an hour building one saves ten hours a quarter.
2. **AI as production assistant:** outlines, first drafts, repurposing. You remain the source of opinions and final edits.
3. **Reinvest 30-50%** of income: a keyword tool, a freelance writer for support content, an editor.

⚠ Update your top earners every 90 days. A stale money page bleeds rankings and refund trust.

\$1,000-\$5,000

MONTHS 12-18



Diversification and the long-term moat

You've built something that works. Now protect it — concentration got you here; concentration is now your biggest risk.

Diversify across four axes, one at a time

1. **Traffic:** no single source above ~60-70% long-term.
2. **Programs:** if one is 80% of revenue, add a comparable alternative now.
3. **Offer types:** stack recurring SaaS, high-ticket bounties, and eventually your own \$19-49 product.
4. **The trust moat:** your name, your tested opinions, your track record of honest calls. Nobody can copy that.

✧ Affiliate income is self-employment income — set aside tax money and talk to a local tax resource.

THIS QUARTER

1. Calculate your concentration: % traffic from top source, % revenue from top program.
2. Apply to one backup program per top category.
3. Write down one product idea you could sell to your list within 6 months.
4. Set up monthly tracking: revenue by program, by page, list growth, tax set-aside.

You're at 100.

Ten stages. None of them required money to start. All of them required showing up when the dashboard said \$0 — and that, not any secret tactic, is the real filter.

The people earning \$5,000/month from affiliate marketing are not smarter than you. They just kept publishing through the silent months while everyone else quit and called it a scam. Start Stage 1 tonight. Not Monday. Tonight.

The 0 to 100 Series

Selling PDFs · Web Dev with AI · Content Creation · Earning Money with AI